MONTHLY UPDATE

Malawi: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-2 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

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Governance

Data protection

UNITED STATES BILATERAL HEALTH AGREEMENT AND ITS DATA-SHARING AGREEMENT

- **US insists specimen data won't be shared** — Nation Online, 1 September 2026

  The US Embassy in Lilongwe said Malawian biological specimens will go to the United States only during public health emergencies and outbreaks, and that no personally identifiable information is shared. The agreement, signed on 11 February 2026 within a five-year US$936 million health package, requires Malawi to supply requested specimens within seven days. Malawian health advocates criticised the clause giving Malawi access to resulting products only after US domestic needs are met.

Regional collaboration

DIGITAL AND INNOVATION COOPERATION WITH JAPAN

- **Japan deepens Malawi innovation ties** — ITWeb Africa, 1 September 2026

  Japan's ambassador to Malawi met the communications regulator's director general with a Japanese delegation, exploring stronger digital and innovation ties. Nothing was signed.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

OPEN GOVERNMENT PARTNERSHIP NATIONAL ACTION PLAN 2025-2028

- **Malawi Action Plan Review 2026-2029 - Open Government Partnership** — Open Government Partnership, 14 October 2026

  The Open Government Partnership's Independent Reporting Mechanism reviewed Malawi's 2026–2029 action plan, which has 11 commitments covering anti-corruption, natural resources, fiscal openness, digital governance and climate. They include a public beneficial ownership register and public party-finance information. The review finds Malawi did not meet the minimum co-creation standards.

Finance

New investments

DIGITAL ACCELERATION PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION REVIEW

- **World Bank begins review of Malawi's $150 million Digital Acceleration Project** — techreviewafrica.com, 1 September 2026

  The World Bank opened a five-day implementation support mission on Malawi's US$150 million Digital Acceleration Project, to review progress and set priorities for the next phase. No disbursement or results figure accompanies it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

COMMUNICATION TOWER PROGRAMME

- **Malawi Activates 36th Rural Telecom Tower to Expand Digital Connectivity** — Tech Africa News, 3 September 2026

  The government switched on the 36th tower under the Last Mile Rural Connectivity Project, at Kalira Village in Traditional Authority Kalumbu.

- **Malawi drives next wave of connectivity** — ITWeb Africa, 3 September 2026

  The World Bank-financed programme carries US$150 million across digital connectivity, the universal service fund's 100-tower rollout, an e-services portal and the national data centre in Lilongwe. Its latest phase is expected to connect more than 500 public institutions and more than 2,000 schools.

DIGITAL MALAWI ACCELERATION PROJECT

- **World Bank turns heat on Malawi's digital transformation project** — Nyasa Times, 3 September 2026

  A World Bank mission reviewed the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project with the communications regulator MACRA. The project manager said a plan for 100 mobile towers in underserved areas has reached procurement preparation, and a consultancy is building the Data Protection Authority's framework and five-year cost model. The mission stressed the quality of MACRA statistics. No funding amounts are stated.

- **DMAP gains momentum as Government, World Bank reaffirm commitment to digital transformation** — Public Private Partnership Commission (PPPC), Malawi, 4 September 2026

  A World Bank mission team on the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project called on the ICT minister in Lilongwe, its task team leader saying the project anticipates funding for around 100 additional cell towers and connectivity for 500 government institutions, with biometric digital ID among key procurements. The minister said existing capacity of 12.5 Gbps is insufficient and called for at least 50 Gbps, a future-ready national data centre and integration of all ministries under the Bomalathu eService Portal.

- **Malawi Advances Next Phase Of Digital Connectivity** — Broadcast Media Africa, 4 September 2026

  Malawi plans to spend US$35m to US$75m on the second phase of the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project, part of a six-year programme with US$150m of World Bank financing. The phase aims to connect more than 500 public institutions, including the National Registration Bureau, and over 2,000 schools; the Public Private Partnership Commission discussed it with ICT providers in Blantyre.

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC ZAMBIA ESWATINI EAST AFRICA SOUTHERN AFRICA

  COMESA's half-year progress report on the World Bank-financed Inclusive Digitalisation in Eastern and Southern Africa programme, a US$2.48 billion envelope, covers January to June 2026 in Angola, the DRC, Malawi, Zambia and Eswatini. The COMESA secretariat had spent 9% of its US$3.71 million 2026 budget by June, and moved its AI and regional digital inclusion consultancies from procurement to implementation.

SCHOOLS WITH LIMITED OR NO INTERNET ACCESS

- **Msukuma calls for digitalization as Malawi schools struggle with connectivity** — 247MALAWI NEWS, 14 September 2026

  Education expert Zizwa Msukuma told 247 Malawi News that digitalisation should be a pillar of Malawi's education reform. He cited a 2026 school connectivity analysis finding that 85.8% of secondary schools lack internet access, 47% have no electricity, one computer serves 356 students on average, and 43% of school computers are in five urban districts.

INDEPENDENT TOWER COMPANY SITE ROLLOUT

- **Helios Towers Expands Rural Connectivity Push in Malawi With 55 New Sites** — Tech Africa News, 15 September 2026

  Helios Towers Malawi said it had built 233 tower sites in 2026, 40% in remote rural areas, with 55 more due by early October. The company gave the figures at a meeting with regulator MACRA, which pressed for lower-cost infrastructure in underserved areas.

HELIOS TOWERS AND UNICEF SCHOOL-CONNECTIVITY PARTNERSHIP (GIGA)

- **Helios Towers partners with UNICEF to accelerate digital inclusion and expand learning opportunities for children across Africa** — UNICEF UK, 28 September 2026 DRC TANZANIA

  Helios Towers and UNICEF announced a multi-year partnership on 28 September 2026 supporting UNICEF's Giga school-connectivity initiative and its Learning Passport digital-learning programme, starting in the Democratic Republic of Congo, Malawi and Tanzania. Helios Towers will support school connectivity mapping and infrastructure. No funding figure is given.

AIRTEL MALAWI CUSTOMER AND DATA BASE

- **Airtel Malawi Revenue Rises 33.8% as Currency Losses Hit Profit** — TechAfrica News, 29 September 2026

  Airtel Malawi's revenue rose 33.8% to K219.1bn in the half-year to June 2026, while exchange losses cut profit by more than half. Customers rose to 9.1 million, data customers to 2.9 million, and capital spending nearly tripled.

REGULATOR INVESTIGATION INTO MOBILE DATA DEPLETION

- **Airtel, TNM face Malawi data probe** — ITWeb Africa, 30 September 2026

  Malawi's regulator MACRA is investigating complaints of rapid data-bundle depletion on Airtel and TNM, examining their charging and billing systems. It had earlier found both operators applied approved tariff rises of 22.2% and 26% before the required seven-day notice.

- **Macra launches mobile data bundle consumption probe** — Nation Online, 1 October 2026

  The Malawi Communications Regulatory Authority opened an investigation, by notice dated 29 September 2026, into complaints that mobile data bundles on TNM and Airtel Malawi run out too fast. It will examine billing systems and usage records and run controlled tests of data used against data deducted, with a deadline of mid-November.

Data Storage

CONVERGED TECHNOLOGY NETWORKS AI-ENABLED EDGE DATA CENTRE, LILONGWE

- **Is Smaller, Better? CTN's bet on AI-enabled edge data centers** — LinkedIn (Brian Munyao Longwe, CEO, Converged Technology Networks), 9 September 2026

  Converged Technology Networks' chief executive, Brian Munyao Longwe, wrote on 9 September 2026 that the company is upgrading its Lilongwe edge data centre, live since February 2026, for AI workloads with support from the EU D4D Hub, and plans further sites in Blantyre, Mzuzu and Zomba alongside 150 new 4G sites. He puts Malawi's fixed broadband connections at about 15,000.

TNM THIRD DATA CENTRE

- **TNM expands Malawi data infrastructure** — ITWeb Africa, 11 September 2026

  Telekom Networks Malawi bought OpenConnect Limited's Tier 3 data centre at Kanengo, Lilongwe, for K12 billion, about US$6.9 million, unveiling it on 11 September 2026. TNM will link it with its Limbe data centre into one cloud platform to offer data centre as a service and host local AI platforms.

NATIONAL DATA CENTRE, LILONGWE

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC ZAMBIA ESWATINI EAST AFRICA SOUTHERN AFRICA

  Summarised under Connectivity.

Cybersecurity

CONSUMER EXPOSURE TO ONLINE SCAMS

- **MACRA sounds alarm over rising digital scams** — Malawi24, 4 September 2026

  The Malawi Communications Regulatory Authority issued a public warning about rising fraud against mobile money users, reported on 4 September 2026. It listed fake social cash transfer messages, spoofed transaction alerts, fake prizes and hijacked WhatsApp accounts. It said government bodies and charities running cash transfers do not ask beneficiaries for money by SMS or WhatsApp.

REGULATOR'S SOCIAL MEDIA MONITORING SYSTEM

- **Questions grow over Malawi's social media monitoring system amid oversight concerns** — Nyasa Times, 8 September 2026

  The Malawi Communications Regulatory Authority installed a social media monitoring system in January 2025 under a $1.5 million contract awarded to Hashcom Ghana Limited 15 days earlier. More than a year on, no published document shows whether it ran during the September 2025 election, what data it collected or who had access. MACRA declined to comment pending an audit.

- **PART 2: A Ghanaian contractor, a $1.5 million contract, and a surveillance system that remains unexplained** — Moz24h, 10 September 2026

  Malawi's communications regulator MACRA bought a $1.5 million social-media monitoring system from Ghana's Hashcom, and more than a year on no institution has said publicly what it collects or who can access it. Civil society letters to MACRA's board, Parliament and the President in early 2025 did not halt it. The human rights commission abandoned a planned inspection, citing a lack of technical expertise.

MOBILE-MONEY SCAMS TRACED TO PRISONS

- **90% of scams linked to prisons** — Malawi24, 15 September 2026

  Malawi's communications regulator, MACRA, said prisoners are behind up to 90% of reported mobile money scams, with Zomba Maximum Security Prison a major source. Methods include SIM swaps, fake promotions, calls demanding border clearance fees for non-existent parcels, and WhatsApp account takeovers. No measures by the prison service or network operators are reported.

DPI

Data Exchange

REGIONAL CUSTOMS-TO-CUSTOMS DATA EXCHANGE ROADMAP

- **Five Southern African countries move to link customs data as trade corridors face pressure to cut delays** — Southern African Times, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA MOZAMBIQUE SOUTH AFRICA ZIMBABWE SOUTHERN AFRICA

  Customs administrations of Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe adopted a roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a meeting in Pretoria on 24-26 August 2026, hosted by the South African Revenue Service and convened by TradeMark Africa. The aim is to share trade data before consignments reach the border, building on existing Zambia-Malawi and Zambia-Zimbabwe links.

AFRICA ACCELERATOR FOR DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE (AA4DPI)

- **CDPI on its session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, 2–3 September 2026** — Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure (CDPI), 3 September 2026 ETHIOPIA RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA

  The Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure led a session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, hosted by UNDP and the Centre for Open Societal Systems on 2 and 3 September 2026. Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia covered DPI blueprints, verifiable credentials, consented data sharing and reusable open-source code.

- **Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure (AA4DPI)** — United Nations Development Programme, 8 September 2026 AFRICA

UNDP has published the standing description of its Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, led jointly by the Regional Bureau for Africa and the Digital and AI Hub, which supports countries to assess digital readiness, strengthen governance, build implementation capacity and develop investment-ready programmes across digital identity, digital payments and data exchange. Its first published cohort session ran on 2 and 3 September with delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia; no budget, duration or deliverable set is published for the accelerator itself.

- **UNDP's AA4DPI Programme Deepens South-South Cooperation on Digital Public Infrastructure** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), 8 September 2026 ETHIOPIA RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA AFRICA

  Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia, with African Union representatives, concluded a two-week South-South learning mission to India on digital public infrastructure. Convened under UNDP's newly launched Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, it took delegates through New Delhi, Pune and Bengaluru to examine India's digital identity, payment and data exchange systems.

INTEGRATION OF GOVERNMENT SYSTEMS WITH THE NATIONAL IDENTITY SYSTEM

- **Malawi advances data harmonization, interoperability agenda | Biometric Update** — Biometric Update, 23 September 2026

  The head of Malawi's communications regulator MACRA, Mayamiko Nkoloma, urged public bodies at an accountants' conference to connect their systems to the National Registration and Identification System. Officials say the human resources department and the agriculture and health ministries are already connected. The speech date is not given.

Digital Identity and CRVS

NZIKA WALLET MOBILE DIGITAL ID

- **Public Statement: Launch of Nzika Digital ID Wallet** — National Registration Bureau (Malawi), 8 September 2026

  Malawi's National Registration Bureau announced that it would launch the Nzika Digital ID Wallet on 16 September 2026 at the Bingu International Convention Centre in Lilongwe, with Homeland Security Minister Peter Mukhito presiding. The bureau says the wallet adds a digital ID to the physical card and will cut printing costs and the time taken to obtain an ID.

- **Malawi set to introduce digital ID wallet** — Malawi24, 10 September 2026

  Malawi's national registration bureau is to introduce a digital identity wallet, giving citizens a digital version of their national identity alongside the existing physical card. It is presented as an additional way of presenting and accessing identification as use of digital services grows.

- **Malawi takes national IDs digital with Nzika wallet** — Channel Africa, 11 September 2026

  Malawi's National Registration Bureau is launching the Nzika wallet on 16 September, an app holding a digital national ID, birth certificate and marriage certificate, downloadable from Google Play and the App Store. Its spokesman, Norman Fulatira, said physical ID cards, held by more than 9 million registered citizens, stay valid because smartphone and internet access remain limited.

- **Malawi to launch digital ID wallet as national ID coverage reaches 99%** — Biometric Update, 11 September 2026

Malawi's National Registration Bureau announced the Nzika Digital ID Wallet, to launch on 16 September 2026, which will hold a digital copy of the national ID card with the same validity as the physical card. The bureau says 99% of citizens hold a national ID and more than 13.5 million people are enrolled; it expects the wallet to cut card-printing costs.

- **Malawi drops expiry dates on national IDs** — Malawi24, 16 September 2026

  Malawi's homeland security minister ordered on 16 September 2026 that national identity cards be issued without expiry dates from that day. He gave the order at the launch of the Nzika digital ID wallet, which lets citizens show government credentials on a phone by QR code.

- **Malawi launches Nzika Digital ID Wallet and removes expiry date from National ID** — UNDP Malawi, 16 September 2026

  Malawi launched the Nzika Digital ID Wallet in Lilongwe on 16 September 2026 and from the same day removed the expiry date from national identity cards. The wallet, built by the National Registration Bureau with UNDP and funded by the EU, Ireland and Norway, holds national IDs and birth, marriage and death certificates. Homeland Security minister Peter Mukhito said it complements the physical card.

- **Digital gap challenges Nzika ID rollout** — Malawi24, 17 September 2026

  Malawi's ICT minister put smartphone ownership at 33 per cent and basic internet skills at 12.5 per cent, saying the gaps could hinder adoption of the digital identity wallet launched the same week in Lilongwe. He called for collaboration between the private sector, civil society and academia to close them.

- **National IDs to last a lifetime** — Nation Online, 17 September 2026

  Malawi's homeland security minister Peter Mukhito announced at the launch of the Nzika Digital ID wallet in Lilongwe that national identity cards will no longer expire, with verification by real-time biometrics against the registration bureau's database. He said 6.6 million children are in the civil registration system, with 3.4 million more targeted by year-end; a cybersecurity expert urged strict limits on data shared with providers.

EXTENSION OF EXPIRED NATIONAL IDENTITY CARD VALIDITY

- **Malawi drops expiry dates on national IDs** — Malawi24, 16 September 2026

  Summarised under Digital Identity and CRVS.

BIOMETRIC LOAN BONDING AGAINST THE NATIONAL REGISTER

- **HESLGB adopts biometric verification linked to NRB** — Malawi24, 17 September 2026

  Malawi's higher education loans and grants board has moved loan-contract bonding onto a paperless process in which students present the national identity card and scan fingerprints on a device linked to the registration bureau's database, which matches the details before bonding completes. The board's stated reason is cost; the 2026/2027 exercise began on 7 September and has so far covered campuses of three universities.

NZIKA DIGITAL ID WALLET

- **Malawi drops ID card expiry date policy as digital wallet launches** — Biometric Update, 18 September 2026

  Malawi launched the Nzika digital ID wallet on International Identity Day, holding national ID, birth, marriage and death credentials on a phone as an optional complement to the physical card. The homeland security minister also ended expiry dates on the biometric ID card with immediate effect.

BIOMETRIC REGISTRATION KIT SUPPLY CONTRACT

- **Nzika Wallet controversy! Who holds the keys to Malawi's multibillion digital identity?** — Malawi24, 26 September 2026

  A Malawi24 investigation reports that a Hong Kong-registered company won a US$5.09 million World Bank-financed contract in March 2026 to supply 2,400 biometric registration kits to the National Registration Bureau, with remote software support. The procurement authority says remote access reaches the kits only; the bureau, the communications regulator and the supplier did not say who else can reach the identity system.

E-KYC AND DIGITAL IDENTITY PROJECT

- **India, UN agencies review e-KYC and Digital Identity Project in Malawi** — IANS, 29 September 2026

  India's High Commissioner to Malawi, Amararam Gujar, met a UNDP and UNCDF delegation on 29 September 2026 to review the e-KYC and Digital Identity Project in Malawi, funded through the India-UN Development Partnership Fund and implemented with partners including the Reserve Bank of Malawi. They discussed its achievements, findings and transition. No funding figure for the project is given.

POINT-OF-CARE DIGITAL BIRTH REGISTRATION

- **Printers to bring registration services closer to Malawians** — Malawi24, 9 October 2026

  UNDP handed Malawi 152 printers to bring birth, marriage and death registration closer to people: 100 for registration offices at Traditional Authority level and 52 for health facilities. The minister said 180 health facilities are already digitalised.

- **UNDP hands over 152 printers to National Registration Bureau to expand civil registration** — United Nations Development Programme, 10 October 2026

  UNDP's own account of the 152 printers handed to Malawi's registration bureau: 100 for registration at Traditional Authority offices and 52 for health facilities. It puts the Nzika registration application in pilot at 87 locations in five districts, with 250 planned by 2028.

Digital Payments and Fintech

ELECTRONIC PAYMENT OF TRAFFIC FINES

- **Malawi police digitises traffic fines** — ITWeb Africa, 4 September 2026

  The Malawi Police Service introduced electronic payment of traffic fines, going live at headquarters in Lilongwe and across the country's six police regions from the week of 4 September, with payment through named commercial banks and both mobile money services. The ICT industry association welcomed it as fraud-reducing but urged the service to secure the system and to train staff and inform the public.

UNCONDITIONAL CASH TRANSFERS PAID BY MOBILE MONEY

- **Canva's $150m Boost Expands GiveDirectly's Lifeline to the Poorest in Malawi** — ednews.africa, 15 September 2026

  A cash-transfer organisation working in Malawi since 2019 expanded after a US$150m donation, paying unconditional lump sums of about US$550 directly to the poorest adults by mobile money.

Registries

KNOW YOUR GROWER BIOMETRIC TOBACCO GROWER REGISTRATION

- **Malawi tobacco farmers face days in the cold amid registration chaos | Nyasa Times** — Nyasa Times, 29 September 2026

> Registration of Malawi's tobacco growers under the new biometric Know Your Grower system, run by the Tobacco Commission with TAMA Farmers Trust, broke down at centres in Lilongwe, Ntcheu and Rumphi, reported on 29 September 2026. Devices failed to sync with the central server and scanners failed to read elderly farmers' fingerprints, leaving farmers camped for days. Unregistered growers get no quota, inputs or auction access.

Sectoral management information systems

> MALAWI HEALTH CARE INFORMATION SYSTEM (MAHIS)

- **Digital health records system in pilot phase** — Nation Online, 4 September 2026

  Malawi's health ministry has begun piloting a digital health records system intended to replace hard-copy health passport books, at Queen Elizabeth Central Hospital in Blantyre and selected health centres nationwide. Each patient is given a unique identifier stored on a server linked to facilities through an interoperability layer, and the ministry expects most facilities digitised within about a year.

> MSCE E-RESULTS AND E-REGISTRATION

- **Malawi exam results move online** — ITWeb Africa, 9 September 2026

  Malawi's education ministry and the national examinations board released the 2026 school certificate results online on 7 September, candidates and examination centres reading them through e-results portals rather than waiting for printed results delivered to districts. The board introduced e-registration in 2022 and the results portals in 2024, and examination fees are now paid through banks and mobile wallets by candidates or parents directly, which it says removes the risk of fees collected by teachers on students' behalf going astray. Of 188,169 candidates, 111,510 passed, a 59.26 per cent pass rate.

> INTEGRATED TAX ADMINISTRATION SYSTEM II (ITAS II)

- **MRA Credits ATAF Support for Tax Administration Reforms, Data Improvements** — Liberian Observer, 12 October 2026

  The Malawi Revenue Authority said it is building a second integrated tax administration system in-house and is still seeking funding for it. It credited its electronic invoicing system, enforced from 1 May, with part of a rise in average monthly VAT collections from MK66.73 billion to MK81.24 billion.

> REVENUE COLLECTED THROUGH THE ELECTRONIC INVOICING SYSTEM

- **MRA Credits ATAF Support for Tax Administration Reforms, Data Improvements** — Liberian Observer, 12 October 2026

  Summarised under Sectoral management information systems.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

> MALAWI NATIONAL ELECTRONIC PROCUREMENT SYSTEM

- **WORLD BANK COMMENDS MANePS PROGRESS** — Public Procurement and Disposal of Assets Authority (Malawi), 7 October 2026

  A World Bank team reviewed progress on Malawi's electronic procurement system MANePS with the procurement authority PPDA in early October 2026 and urged more training so that all public bodies use it by December 2026. As of 5 October the system had 7,417 registered suppliers, 216 of 250 targeted annual procurement plans published and 562 tenders. MANePS is World Bank-funded.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

YOUTH IN LEADERSHIP INNOVATION CHALLENGE

- **Three district councils win Youth in Leadership Innovation Challenge** — UNDP Malawi, 14 September 2026

  Malawi's Zomba, Likoma and Mangochi district councils won US$20,000 under the Youth in Leadership Innovation Challenge, announced by the youth ministry and UNDP in Lilongwe on 11 September 2026. The councils will develop and test youth-led digital solutions to local service-delivery problems within their existing systems.

- **Malawians embrace digital rights, urge accountability** — Nation Online, 15 September 2026

  Three district councils each won US$20,000 under a youth innovation challenge to develop and test youth-led digital solutions to service delivery problems inside existing council systems.

Rural digital data capture

DIGITALISATION OF POLICE STATIONS

- **Empowering Malawi Police to Respond to Emerging Digital and Community Security Challenges** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP Malawi), 1 September 2026

  Malawi Police officers were trained to identify, preserve and analyse digital evidence, as offences committed through digital platforms grow more complex.

Technology

AI

COUNTRY-HOSTED AI COMPUTE (UNDP AI INFRASTRUCTURE ACTIVATION)

- **Local AI compute infrastructure in Africa: Lessons from six country-hosted deployments on governance and effective use** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), Regional Bureau for Africa, 17 September 2026 KENYA RWANDA SOUTH AFRICA TOGO ZAMBIA AFRICA

  The UN Development Programme's Africa bureau published lessons on 17 September 2026 from the AI computing capacity it deployed in Kenya, Malawi, Rwanda, South Africa, Togo and Zambia. It identified 21 AI applications across the six, and found that data readiness, skills, institutional ownership and financing, not hardware, determine how far the compute is used.

SMART CITY SURVEILLANCE INITIATIVE, BLANTYRE AI CAMERAS

- **MACRA and Blantyre City Assembly Explore AI-Powered Smart City Surveillance** — Tech Africa News, 28 September 2026

  The regulator's engagement with Blantyre City Assembly on AI cameras able to detect objects and interpret incidents in real time was welcomed by the city's chief executive and mayor.

- **Malawi backs AI crime cameras** — ITWeb Africa, 28 September 2026

  Malawi's regulator backed AI-powered crime cameras for Blantyre after meeting city officials, with the police and road traffic directorate as partners. No budget, supplier or timetable is stated.

- **Malawi's Telecoms Regulator Proposes AI Surveillance Network for Blantyre** — iAfrica.com, 28 September 2026

> Malawi's communications regulator recommended AI surveillance cameras for Blantyre under its Smart City Surveillance Initiative, a pilot combining number-plate recognition, traffic monitoring and a central command centre at four sites. No cost, supplier, timeline or rules on footage have been published, and the country has no AI policy yet.

Inclusion

Access to services

DIGITAL PLANT HEALTH SERVICE

- **Malawian farmers help shape digital plant-health services** — NIBIO (Norwegian Institute of Bioeconomy Research), 4 September 2026

  Farmers, extension workers, agro-dealers and policymakers tested Malawi's digital plant-health service and proposed changes before wider rollout. Its voice platform reaches basic-phone users in Chichewa and other local languages and takes around 30,000 calls a month despite never having been publicly promoted since its June 2025 launch; participants asked for coverage of soil health, fertilisers, irrigation and weather and for changes to visualisations, language and accessibility.

Digital divides

SMARTPHONE OWNERSHIP AND BASIC INTERNET SKILLS

- **Digital gap challenges Nzika ID rollout** — Malawi24, 17 September 2026

  Summarised under Digital Identity and CRVS.

Data

Open data

OUTCOMES OF ACCESS-TO-INFORMATION REQUESTS

- **When information requests go nowhere** — Malawi24, 16 September 2026

  A Malawi24 investigation published on 16 September 2026 found that 65 per cent of 30 surveyed requesters received no reply within the 15 days set by Malawi's Access to Information Act. The outlet filed requests with ten public bodies, including the Anti-Corruption Bureau, the health ministry and the revenue authority, and none supplied the information. The Human Rights Commission said it can only make recommendations, as the Act carries no penalties.

Geopolitics

India activities

INDIA DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE LEARNING MISSION

- **Karnataka Hosts African Union, Five African Nations For Digital Public Infrastructure Exposure Visit** — The Bengaluru Live, 1 September 2026 ETHIOPIA RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA

  The Indian state of Karnataka hosted officials from the African Union, Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on 1 September 2026, on a UNDP-supported visit to study digital public infrastructure. State officials and the Centre for e-Governance briefed the delegation on digitising public services and interoperability between government systems.

- **African Delegations Explore India's Digital Public Infrastructure During UNDP Learning Mission** — Youth Village Zambia, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA ETHIOPIA RWANDA SIERRA LEONE

  The UN Development Programme in India hosted delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on a learning mission on digital public infrastructure in New Delhi, Pune and Bangalore in early September 2026. The visits covered Aadhaar digital identity, the Unified Payments Interface and DigiLocker, with meetings at India's identity authority, its national payments corporation and the health and agriculture ministries.

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